

Develop and Demonstrate Loyalty: Being Loyal While Managing Conflict, Featuring Joan Cronan

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Most of us don't like conflict. It's uncomfortable.

Emotions get involved. People get defensive. Some people get angry.

(It's) better to avoid the hard conversations ... right? Wrong! Wrong!

So how do you get into one of those uncomfortable conversations? There is a six-step framework for navigating those tough encounters.

First, own the conversation.

Start the conversation with -- "I have a problem," or "I have a concern that I want to discuss."

Never start with -- "You've got a problem we need to discuss" because you immediately put the other person on the defense. Own the conversation.

Second, position the conversation to disarm the tension. Say something like, "I'm concerned that this conversation will hurt our relationship, and I don't want to do that."

When people sense a hard conversation is coming, tensions build. So disarm it.

Third, describe the situation factually. Say something like, "I observed, I heard, or I noticed." But keep it factual.

Fourth, describe the impact. "When that happened, or when you said that, I felt, or I thought, or I believed, or I was confused because" But describe the impact on you.

Fifth, ask for any response or perspective from the other person. You'll ask something like, "How do you see what happened?" Amazingly, the perspective we have going into one of these conversations is not always right.

Finally, state your request.

Oh, yeah. You need something out of this conversation, so you may say something like, "It would really help me if ...," or "I would appreciate if you would" You need to communicate your desired outcome and obtain their buy-in.

Coach Summitt believed passionately that human beings will do more for others than they'll do for themselves. It was perhaps the most important truth to her about the human spirit and the power of a team.

By developing and demonstrating loyalty, difficult conversations become more productive.